

Dr Weliton Menário Costa (Dr WELI)

Scientist-artist · Creative innovator · Founder, WildWooHoo

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Citizenship: **Italian (EU)** · Brazilian · Australian (conferred 23 September 2026). No visa, permit or sponsorship is required to work or travel in the European Union. Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (intermediate). NSW Working with Children Check WWC2779967E, to 01/12/2028.

Profile

I am a scientist-artist and creative innovator who turns complex ideas into creative experiences, joining behavioural-ecology research (PhD, ANU) with music, film, performance and public programs so that science lands with audiences of every age. My research-creation project *Kangaroo Time* was the **AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024**. Through my studio, *WildWooHoo*, I design keynotes, workshops, performances, educational programs and original creative productions, and I write on science in popular culture as a Visiting Fellow at ANU's Centre for the Public Awareness of Science. I coined and defined **sci pop**, the genre term for popular songs that carry science as aesthetic, theme or method, in a citable founding text. My work runs in English and Portuguese, and reaches corporate, university, school, festival and public audiences across Australia, Brazil, Europe, the United Kingdom and the United States.

Length of professional creative practice: sixteen years of scientific practice and more than five years of professional creative practice. Performing ran right through the doctorate, 2017 to 2021, and a field photograph of mine is published and credited to me in my 2021 ANU thesis (Figure 2, p. 15).

Europe: the record that already exists

- **German public television.** UFA Show & Factual GmbH (Cologne, a Fremantle company) licensed the *Kangaroo Time* footage in 2024 for *Wer weiß denn sowas?!* (ARD, Das Erste), illustrating a quiz question on the research behind it. Four-year licence, credited "WELI - Kangaroo Time, from ANU".
 - **Austrian press.** *Kleine Zeitung*, 29 February 2024, "Australischer Känguru-Forscher wird zur 'globalen Tanz-Sensation'": kleinezeitung.at/artikel/18228448.
 - **German press.** *Süddeutsche Zeitung*, 27 February 2024, "Von Kängurus lernen: Preis für Tanzvideo": sueddeutsche.de/panorama/tiere-doktorarbeit-kurioses-anruf-bei-australien-1.6401819.
 - **Athens Science Festival**, with *SciCo Greece*, May 2025. My workshop *Science and the People*, delivered to a European audience.
 - **Falling Walls Engage**, Berlin, 2025. **Top 30 worldwide**, for *Science and the People*.
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Signature contributions and coined terms

- **"Complex ideas into creative experiences"**: my positioning and practice, sourcing from research, reports and strategy and giving ideas a form audiences remember (music, film, performance, programs).
 - **"Sci pop"**: a genre term I coined for popular songs that carry science as aesthetic, theme or method, ranging from real research to the fictional cultural imaginary. What makes a song sci pop is intention: sourcing from science, and bringing scientific thinking into the songwriting and production. Founding text deposited and citable, Zenodo 2026, CC BY 4.0: doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21387515.
 - **The five-step live-experience method**: every energiser, workshop, keynote or performance runs the same five steps. (1) Start together, in movement: open with collective movement, out of static, before any idea. (2) Bring in the idea: introduce the finding or concept and find its human angle. (3) Translate it: carry the idea into music, movement, story or image so people feel it. (4) Make it together: people take part and make something with the idea. (5) Leave one clear thing: a single idea they keep and can act on.
 - **Principles**: participation and co-creation · inclusion and access · culture and belonging · emotion and wonder · translation and language.
 - **The Interconnected Narrative method**: my making method for composing science-sourced artwork, where one unit of the work is literally true inside the scientific narrative and inside the human narrative at the same time (practice-based; see Research).
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Selected creative and artistic production

- **Kangaroo Time (2024)**: research-creation song, film and dance work made from my own doctoral research on kangaroo personality. I co-wrote the song, and wrote, cast, directed and performed in the film, with a dance cast of twenty-four drawn from multicultural Canberra, none of them performers by trade. **AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall**

Winner 2024, the overall prize across all four categories. [Dance Your PhD edit](#) · [Kids edit](#)

- **Cabra da Peste (G.O.A.T.) (2024)**: original Latin pop song built from my own undergraduate research on goat social hierarchy, commissioned for and performed at the [opening plenary](#) of the XLI Encontro Anual de Etologia, Brazil, on the plenary theme “Creativity and Science unifying communities”. Co-written and performed with Jon Panic (Black Bird Hum). The talk and the song were one commission.
- **Yours Academically, Dr. WELI** (EP): released. Science, queer and Latin-immigrant narratives across reggaeton, electronic and Brazilian funk.
- **EVER+GROW**: first sci pop album by WELI. In development, recording December 2026, launch Q2 2027.
- **Kanga-Kangaroo**: animated series. In development.
- **Children’s field-guide booklet line**: science booklets for young readers. In development, launch planned 2027.
- **The Photography Project** (shot 2023, released 2024): staged portrait series translating the doctoral findings into people. Concept and creative direction mine; photographed by Tony Oliver and Reid Workman.
- **Kangaroo Time Kids**: schools program translating the research into science, music and movement for students.
- **Sync catalogue**: cleared catalogue for television, film, documentary, advertising and brand work. International sync placements across three broadcasters, 2024.
- **WELI (recording and performing artist; songwriter)**: original music celebrating science, drawing on Latin, Brazilian and Afro influences. Songwriter across the sci pop catalogue, with production delivered through studio producers and collaborators. **APRA AMCOS songwriter member since 2023**. Released and streamable catalogue: drweli.com/music.

Broader performance, dance and screen

- **Brazilian dance and dance fitness**: led guided dance-fitness classes and Brazilian-hits choreography with Só Samba Canberra and Rio Samba Shows, 2022 to 2024, including teaching at Blank, 2023. Continues to perform Brazilian carnival sets with the crew at ACT festivals. Dance-fitness training, 2021.
- **Screen and modelling**: screen extra, including *Young Rock* (Gold Coast, 2021, via 888 Agency); photographic modelling (Victoria Models, 2020).

WildWooHoo, creative innovation studio

Founder and Creative Director, 2026 to present; creative-innovation practice since 2024

WildWooHoo takes complex ideas from research papers, reports and strategy documents and turns them into creative experiences: the music, films and books we make, and the keynotes, workshops and performances we bring to a room. See the work at wildwoohoo.com/work and the approach at wildwoohoo.com/method.

What I deliver, four formats plus a partnership: **Keynotes**, talks that make science and ideas move a room · **Workshops**, hands-on sessions that turn research into creative, memorable learning for teams, students and HDR researchers · **Consultancy**, evidence-informed public engagement, communication and program design · **Creative productions**, commissioned music, film and educational materials · **Creative Research Engagement Partnership**, a 6 to 12 month retainer with one organisation at a time.

Programs by audience (drweli.com/program): Corporate (conference keynotes, team workshops, creative-thinking activations) · Universities (research translation, student engagement) · Schools (STEAM incursions in science, music and movement) · Science x Art (original collaborative projects).

Keynotes, performance and public programming

- **Co-host, *The Visionaries Among Us***, ANU 80th anniversary, Manning Clark Hall, August 2026, with Lee Constable. Program spanning deep human history, large language models and deep space.
- **Opening plenary**, with the commissioned performance of *Cabra da Peste*, Encontro Anual de Etologia, Brazil, 2024.
- **Three Minute Thesis half-time show**, Llewellyn Hall, ANU, 2024.
- **Athens Science Festival**, with SciCo Greece, 2025.
- **Floriade**, Canberra, 2025 · **Canberra Multicultural Festival**.
- **ACT National Science Week**, 2024 and 2025, with Inspiring Australia ACT.
- **ANU HDR Research Festival** · **Guest lecture**, ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science · **ANU Commencement 2025**, co-master of ceremonies · **Resilience Workshop**, closing keynote.
- **Falling Walls Engage**, Berlin, 2025: **Top 30 worldwide**, for *Science and the People*.

Engagement formats: keynotes and conference energisers · science-art residencies and commissions · festival and community engagement · university and Dance Your PhD workshops · the Kangaroo Time Kids classroom program. For corporate, university, school, festival and public audiences across Australia, Brazil, Europe, the United Kingdom and the United States. Full engagement record: wildwoohoo.com/engagement.

Research

I run three strands of research, and my artistic practice sits inside them: peer-reviewed science underneath, current academic research into how science lives in popular culture, and creative research that feeds directly into what I make. The making and the studying happen together. This is what makes the practice scientist-artist: the science background and the artistry working as one body of work.

Scientific research, behavioural ecology

- Menário Costa, W., King, W. J., Bonnet, T., Festa-Bianchet, M., and Kruuk, L. E. B. (2023). Early-life behavior, survival, and maternal personality in a wild marsupial. *Behavioral Ecology*, 34(6), 1002 to 1012.
- **Doctoral thesis:** Menário Costa, W. (2021). *Personality, social environment, and maternal-level effects: insights from a wild kangaroo population*, 266 pp. The Australian National University. Supervisors: Prof. Loeske Kruuk (ANU) and Prof. Marco Festa-Bianchet (Université de Sherbrooke). Four years of quantitative field research on a wild eastern grey kangaroo population underpins it.

Academic research, current: science communication and science in popular culture Visiting Fellow (Honorary), [ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science](#). Research line: science in music and popular culture. Collaborator: Dr Anna-Sophie Jürgens. Oversight: Prof. Sujatha Raman.

- *Principles of effective engagement with music in and for science communication*, with Anna-Sophie Jürgens, Graham Walker and Gypsy Cook (ANU CPAS). **In preparation.** Sets out principles across narrative, multimodality, inclusion and access, participation, and the outcomes of music, with *Kangaroo Time* as a worked case.
- *Ack! Ack! Ack! Aliens, Camp Science and Science Communication in Film*, book chapter with Anna-Sophie Jürgens, Karina Judd and Anastasiya Fiadotava. Proposes the concept of “camp science” through science-fiction cinema (*Santa Claus* 1959, *Mars Attacks!* 1996, *Men in Black II* 2002). **In review**, for the Routledge volume *Humour and Science Communication*.

Creative research, independent, through WildWooHoo

- Menário Costa, W. (2026). *Sci pop: science as aesthetic, theme and method in contemporary popular music*. Zenodo, CC BY 4.0. doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21387515. **The founding text coining and defining the term.**
- *The Interconnected Narrative method*, artistic-research article on the science-to-artwork composition method I use to build science-sourced work. **In preparation.**

Research interests, forward directions Forward interests sit at the intersection of comparative cognition, cultural cognition and cultural musicology.

- Human and animal cognition and social-system parallels: behavioural-ecology constructs read across species as comparative biology.
- Cultural cognition and routine thinking: culturally transmitted thought templates about nature, evolution and the species we share the planet with.
- Collective imaginaries and emotion in music and popular culture.
- The evolved brain in synthetic environments: evolutionary mismatch, attention, mental health, child neurodevelopment.

Full research profile: drweli.com/academic. Forthcoming titles are working titles; collaborators named above; venues and dates confirmed where noted.

Selected collaborations

- **Jon Panic** (Black Bird Hum): co-writer and performer, *Cabra da Peste*.
 - **Nic Vevers** (ANU Science): production, *Kangaroo Time* video.
 - **Nicholas Moynihan**: soundscape and composition.
 - **Dr Anna-Sophie Jürgens** (ANU CPAS): research collaborator, science in popular culture.
 - **Simon Clews** (HDR researcher-development advisor, ANU): HDR student development and the Three Minute Thesis half-time show, Llewellyn Hall, ANU, 2024.
 - **Tony Oliver** and **Reid Workman**: photography, The Photography Project, 2023.
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Recognition and awards

- **AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024**, for *Kangaroo Time*. The overall prize across all four categories, AU\$4,000.
- **Falling Walls Engage Top 30 worldwide 2025**, for *Science and the People*.
- **Judge**, AAAS Dance Your PhD, 2025.

Grants, scholarships and funding

- **Social Policy Group**, 2024. AU\$20,000 excl. GST, for CALD-inclusive events combining science and music. Delivered and acquitted.
- **ACT National Science Week / Inspiring Australia ACT**, 2024. AU\$1,700, for *Cabra da Peste*. Delivered and acquitted.
- **Holsworth Wildlife Research Endowment**, 2017 to 2020. Field-research funding for the kangaroo doctorate.
- **ANU International PhD Scholarship**, 2017 to 2020, approx. AU\$26,288 per year, and **ANU HDR Fee Remission Merit Scholarship**, 2017 to 2021.

Media

238+ media features across five continents for *Kangaroo Time* (Isentia 2024; estimated potential reach above 15 million). Full coverage: drweli.com/media.

Selected: *Science* (AAAS, 26 Feb 2024) · *The Guardian*, “Joyful madness: ANU scientist wins global prize for dancing his PhD about kangaroos”, 27 Feb 2024 · *Smithsonian Magazine*, 28 Feb 2024 · **MSNBC The 11th Hour** with Stephanie Ruhle, “Last Thing Before We Go: Kangaroo Time”, 1 Mar 2024 · *NPR*, Morning Edition and All Things Considered, Mar and May 2024 · *Kleine Zeitung* (Austria), 29 Feb 2024 · *Süddeutsche Zeitung* (Germany), 27 Feb 2024 · *O Globo* (Brazil), 29 Feb 2024 · ABC News (Australia) · BBC · Australian Geographic · Cosmos · LGBT Nation.

Positions and affiliations

- **Visiting Fellow (Honorary)**, [Centre for the Public Awareness of Science](#), ANU College of Systems and Society, 2025 to 2027, renewed for a second term.
- **Founder and Creative Director**, WildWooHoo, 2026 to present; creative-innovation practice since 2024.
- **Research Data Scientist**, UNSW, 2025 to 2026: student-experience and academic-quality analytics.
- **University Tutor**, Research School of Biology, ANU, 2019 to 2021: animal behaviour, ecology and statistical thinking.
- **Queer Officer**, PARSA, ANU, 2019 to 2020: LGBTQ+ inclusion events across science and the arts.
- **artsACT Artist Database**, 2026: listed as Dr WELI under Interdisciplinary, Music, Performance, Producer and Screen.
- **Australian Independent Record Labels Association (AIR)**, Artist member, 2026 · **APRA AMCOS**, songwriter member, 2023.

Education and training

- **PhD, Ecology and Evolution**, The Australian National University, 2017 to 2021. Supervisors: Prof. Loeske Kruuk and Prof. Marco Festa-Bianchet.
- **Licenciatura and Bacharelado, Biological Sciences**, [Instituto Federal do Espírito Santo](#), Brazil, from 2010, with a Science Without Borders exchange at Griffith University, Australia, 2013 to 2014.
- **Voice and songwriting**: four short courses at the Open Academy, Sydney Conservatorium of Music, University of Sydney, 2025 to 2026, plus private voice and performance coaching (ANU School of Music, NIDA short courses, Canberra vocal coaches).

Capabilities

Creative direction · science communication and research translation · songwriting, with production delivered through studio producers and collaborators · live performance and dance · film and audiovisual scripting and creative direction, with videography and editing outsourced · workshop facilitation and program design · keynote speaking · experimental design, field data collection, quantitative analysis and scientific writing · bilingual delivery in English and Portuguese, with short sessions also in Spanish.